Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) in Arunachal Pradesh predictably feels that indigenous, animist Donyi Polo is just another strand of Hinduism, and the state government is pushing Hindu religious tourism. I worry about cow belt politics muscling in on this state's gender-equal, bovine-eating identity, and hope that tourism can be balanced with all that makes Arunachal beautiful.

Overnight rain in Pasighat falls on my cottage at Oken Tayeng's wonderful Aborcountry River Camp resort on the banks of Siang river, whose wild beauty I saw on a rafting expedition four years ago. The morning is clear, and the road to Pakke-Kesang is a joy. Last year's halt at Pakke-Kesang was magical—a circle of tents under popping stars, in a large green surrounded by hills—but at the new Four Sisters Resort right on the road, run by a Nyishi man in traditional hornbill headgear, I do appreciate an actual bathroom.

It should be seven hours to Dirang village, but a landslide has deposited a tree across the road. We have a misty, drizzly coffee break while the bulldozers work, and we're off again. Arunachal is generally gorgeous, but around Rupa and Shergaon it's especially gorgeous, with yellows and reds and lacy streams whipped about by rain and breeze. The Sherdukpen people of the region claim both Tibetan and Assamese heritage, and cultivate fruit.

A PARTY IN DIRANG

Dirang is a party—literally a party, at the home of trip boss Lhakpa Tsering. First, a cultural welcome—a short taste of an all-night Ramayana story, performed by masked, whirling dancers—and thereafter, it's all karaoke and dance, because Arunachalis love a good piss-up with music. I have two face-numbing sips of the house ara offered by Lhakpa's wife, and discreetly abandon the tumbler. But she sees my empty hands and gives me another. I go in search of something gentler, like neat whisky, or rocket fuel.

I unexpectedly survive this event, and live to drive the foggy road up, up to the 13,700-ft Sela Pass; we burst into the sun and find ourselves looking down on a duvet of clouds, like a bunch of slightly hungover angels. Last year, the pass was snowy, the Sela Lake frozen; now it's all bright wildflowers and clear water, but the wind still means business. We descend into Tawang district and stop at the spectacular Jang Falls, a.k.a. Nuranang Falls—a big, bouncy, crashing thing with rainbows dancing in its mists.

The light is fading in Tawang town when we put our bags down in the guesthouse of the 400-year-old Gaden Namgyal Lhatse monastery, or simply 'Tawang monastery'. Don't miss that or the 1962 War Memorial commemorating those who died fighting the Chinese. Last year, I saw the battlefield at Walong, on the other end of the state, where so many others died in 1962. It's ironic that Arunachalis, often targets of xenophobic comments by fellow Indians, are a particularly patriotic lot.

Between my two trans-Arunachal Drives, I can tell you that Arunachal is brilliant. Its people are interesting and kind. It's a world biodiversity heritage site. It's safe for solo travellers, including women. Go and enjoy it—don't despoil it, or abuse its hospitality, or try to turn it into something you're used to. ■



The 80-ft statue of Jetsun Dolma, or Tara Devi, at Lumla (45 km from Tawang) overlooking Tibet

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